

ENG 111: Public Speaking

- Lecture 5: Language
- Fall 2026 | Class 5 | Chapter 14
- How language choices shape meaning, clarity, credibility, and audience response

Today's Class

- Recap & warm-up — 10 min
- What is language? — 10 min
- Language and meaning — 15 min
- Effective language choices — 20 min
- Pair work — 15 min
- Group work — 15 min
- Reflection & wrap-up — 5 min

Warm-Up: One Idea, Different Words

- Compare: “The university changed the policy.”
- “The university finally changed the policy.”
- “The university suddenly changed the policy.”
- DISCUSS: What extra meaning does each word create?
- Sample explanation: “Finally” suggests something took a long time; “suddenly” suggests unexpected change. Word choice can reveal a speaker’s attitude.

What Is Language?

- Language is a system of symbols and rules used to communicate meaning.
- Public speakers choose not only WHAT to say, but HOW to frame an idea.
- Example: “There was a problem” is less specific than “The system failed to provide students with timely information.”
- Clear language helps an audience understand the speaker’s exact meaning.

Language and Meaning

- Meaning can be influenced by context, experience, culture, relationship, and tone.
- Example: “That was brave.” can be sincere praise or criticism.
- Ask: What happened before the statement? Who said it? Who heard it?
- Sample explanation: The same words can produce different interpretations because audiences bring their own experiences and the situation changes meaning.

Language Should Be Appropriate

- Effective language fits the audience, occasion, purpose, and topic.
- Informal: “Lots of students are freaking out about exams.”
- Formal presentation: “Many students experience considerable stress during examination periods.”
- Neither is automatically wrong. The situation determines what is appropriate.

Language Should Be Clear

- Avoid unnecessary complexity when a simpler expression works.
- Wordy: “At this point in time, students are in the process of making preparations for exams.”
- Clear: “Students are preparing for exams.”
- Explanation: Clear language reduces the audience’s mental effort so they can focus on your ideas.

Avoid Jargon When Necessary

- Jargon is specialized language used by a particular profession or group.
- Jargon can be useful when the audience understands it.
- Example: A computer science speaker says “API,” “latency,” and “deployment pipeline” to a general audience without explanation.
- Better: Explain an unfamiliar technical term the first time you use it.

Use Specific Language

- Vague: “The program helped many people.”
- Specific: “The program provided 120 first-year students with weekly academic advising.”
- Specific language makes a claim easier to understand and evaluate.
- Ask: Who? What? How many? When? Where?

Use Concrete Examples

- Abstract: “Social media affects students.”
- Concrete: “A student who repeatedly checks social media while studying may lose concentration and spend less time on coursework.”
- Explanation: Concrete examples help audiences picture how an abstract idea operates in real life.

Language Can Create Images

- Plain: “The campus was crowded.”
- Vivid: “By 8:30 a.m., the hallway was packed with students moving between classes.”
- Vivid language can make a speech memorable.
- Tip: Use enough detail to create a picture without overwhelming the audience.

Inclusive and Respectful Language

- Language can include people—or make them feel excluded.
- Avoid unnecessary stereotypes and broad assumptions.
- Instead of: “Older people cannot understand technology.”
- Better: “Some people with less exposure to new technologies may need additional support.”
- Explanation: The revised version is more precise and does not treat an entire group as identical.

Language and Bias

- Words can influence how audiences evaluate people, events, and ideas.
- Compare: “The protestors demanded change.”
- versus “The protestors caused chaos.”
- Both describe an event, but the second adds a negative judgment.
- DISCUSS: How can word choice reveal a speaker’s attitude?

Loaded Language

- Loaded words carry strong positive or negative associations.
- Examples: “freedom fighter” vs. “terrorist”; “reform” vs. “cutbacks”; “investment” vs. “expense.”
- Explanation: Word choice can influence audience reactions before evidence is even presented.
- Ethical speakers should recognize when language is framing an issue emotionally.

Euphemisms and Harsh Language

- A euphemism uses a softer expression for something unpleasant.
- Example: “passed away” instead of “died.”
- Sometimes softer language is respectful and appropriate.
- But vague wording can also hide important information.
- Speaker’s task: be both respectful and honest.

PAIR WORK 1: Improve the Language

- Rewrite for a university presentation:
- 1. “The thing is really bad.”
- 2. “Everybody knows this is true.”
- 3. “Students have many issues.”
- 4. “Technology is messing everything up.”
- Make each statement more specific, balanced, and credible.

Pair Work 1: Sample Answers

- “The service has caused difficulties for some students.”
- “Available evidence suggests that this is an important issue.”
- “Some students experience difficulties with workload and deadlines.”
- “Some students experience difficulties when new technologies are introduced without adequate training.”
- Why stronger? The revisions avoid exaggeration and make claims more precise.

PAIR WORK 2: Change the Audience

- Message: “University students need better time management.”
- Version A: Say it to a close friend.
- Version B: Say it in a formal presentation.
- Version C: Say it to parents at a university orientation.
- Discuss: What changes in vocabulary, tone, examples, and detail?

Sample Pair Explanation

- Friend: “You really need to stop leaving everything until the last minute.”
- Formal: “Students can improve academic performance by planning tasks and allocating time effectively.”
- Parents: “Students benefit from developing routines that help them balance coursework, deadlines, and other responsibilities.”
- Explanation: The core idea stays the same, but the vocabulary and tone change with the audience.

GROUP ACTIVITY 1: Language Detectives

- Groups of 4–5.
- Analyze: “Lazy students waste their parents’ money by spending all day on their phones.”
- Identify: generalizations, loaded words, unsupported assumptions, and missing information.
- Then rewrite the statement in a neutral, credible form.
- Prepare to explain TWO changes your group made.

Sample Group Explanation

- Problematic words: “lazy,” “waste,” and “all day.”
- These make broad judgments without evidence.
- Possible revision: “Some students may spend substantial time on smartphones, which can interfere with academic responsibilities.”
- Note: If presented as a factual claim, the revised statement still needs appropriate evidence.

GROUP ACTIVITY 2: Make It Speech-Ready

- Choose one: AI in education, social media use, environmental responsibility, academic integrity, or healthy campus life.
- Create a 45-second mini-message using:
 - One specific claim
 - One concrete example
 - Audience-appropriate vocabulary
 - Clear language
 - One memorable phrase

Group Presentation & Feedback

- Each group presents for 45 seconds.
- Audience listens for: clarity, specificity, appropriate language, concrete example, and possible bias.
- Feedback formula:
- “Your strongest language choice was...”
- “One phrase you could make more precise is...”

Language Editing Challenge

- Original: “This app is the best thing ever and everyone should use it.”
- Possible revision: “For students who need to organize deadlines, this app can be useful because it combines reminders and task lists.”
- Explanation: The revision makes a limited, supportable claim rather than an absolute claim.
- Question: What evidence would you need to make the claim stronger?

Key Takeaways

- Language shapes meaning and audience response.
- Choose language appropriate to audience, purpose, occasion, and topic.
- Be clear, specific, concrete, and respectful.
- Explain jargon when necessary.
- Recognize loaded and biased language.
- Avoid unnecessary exaggeration and unsupported generalizations.
- Effective language makes a speech easier to understand and more credible.

Exit Ticket

- 1. Rewrite: “Everybody hates online classes.”
- 2. Give one example of loaded language.
- 3. What language habit do you want to improve?
- 4. In one sentence: Why does word choice matter to a public speaker?

Next Class: Delivery

- Think about this question:
- If two speakers use exactly the same words, why might one speaker sound much more effective than the other?
- Next class we explore delivery: how voice, pace, pauses, pronunciation, and physical presentation affect a speech.